

****Title:** I Did All the Visibility Work for My Team. It Was My Biggest Failure.**

****Quick Bridge:**** You might be carrying something your team has never seen. The stakeholder meetings, the internal advocacy, the relationships with people who control priorities. You handle it because you know how. Your team produces while you make sure the right people notice the production. That feels like protection. Here is what it actually is, and three things to do differently before you move on.

My biggest failure was my first management role.

I had a small team. We produced a great amount of value, and we had real visibility inside the company. People knew who we were. People knew what we were building. Projects were prioritized. Resources came through. The team was seen.

Most of that was on my effort.

I spent hours every week grooming backlogs, meeting with internal customers, and marketing what the team was building. I took the stakeholder meetings. I built the relationships with the leaders whose priorities shaped our work. I made sure the right people knew what we were shipping and why it mattered.

The team delivered. I made sure people noticed the delivery.

The failure I did not see

I never brought my team into any of it.

I never showed them the conversations I was having. I never explained the relationships I was building or why those relationships existed. I let them sit at their desks and produce, while I handled the work of making sure other people knew how and why they were successful.

I thought I was protecting them. Freeing them to focus on the work they were good at. Taking the organizational complexity off their plates so they could build.

A couple of years into that role, my responsibilities were significantly expanded and I was promoted. Suddenly, everything I had been doing for that team just stopped. I did not have room in my schedule to maintain it. Nobody picked it up. Nobody knew it needed to be picked up.

The team fell into what I can only describe as mild obscurity. Projects slipped down the priority list. Resources got harder to secure. Career conversations became harder because there was less to point to.

I built that obscurity. Not by doing something wrong. By doing too much right, and doing it alone.

What I got wrong

The failure was not that I worked hard. The failure was treating visibility as my job to carry and my team's job to ignore.

Visibility is not a management perk. It is a team skill. And if you carry it for your team instead of teaching it, you have not made them successful. You have made them dependent.

When I got promoted, nobody had the instincts or the relationships to pick up what I had been doing. Not because they were not capable. Because they had never done it. Because I had never shown them it needed to be done.

Here is the thing I eventually had to sit with: **if you are irreplaceable to your team, you are also not promotable.** Not just because of what that means for your career. Because of what it means for theirs. The team I left behind spent years rebuilding the visibility I had been hoarding.

The pattern

This is a pattern I see consistently in first-time managers who came from technical roles.

You come from a world where doing the work well is the primary metric. Then you become a manager and discover a second job: making sure the right people know the work is happening. Because you already know how to do that job and your team does not, you carry it yourself.

That is not mentorship. It is gatekeeping dressed up as protection.

Your team cannot advocate for their work if you are always the one doing it for them. That skill does not grow in the dark. It only develops when someone has to actually use it.

[object Object]

What the shift looks like

The goal is not to stop doing stakeholder work yourself. You still take those meetings. The shift is that you stop taking them alone.

****Bring someone with you.**** Pick one team member and take them into a meeting where they would normally never go. A stakeholder review, a cross-team planning session, a conversation with your manager's peers. Let them see how those conversations actually work.

Let them be in the room and ask a question. Let them watch how decisions get made before they ever have to make one.

If you cannot bring someone, debrief afterward. Walk through what happened. What did you tell your internal customers? What did they care about? What do they still want to know? Give your team the map, even when they were not in the meeting.

****Start naming work in outcomes.**** Once a week, in a team meeting or in whatever channel your team uses, name what shipped and why it matters in a sentence that a non-technical leader could say back to their boss. Not "we closed 14 tickets." More like: "We shipped the new API integration, which means the compliance team can pull audit reports in two minutes instead of two hours."

Teach your team to speak in outcomes. Then ask them to bring that language to the next update.

Introduce your team to your relationships. If you have a peer leader, a business partner, or a stakeholder who matters, make the introduction explicitly: "This is [name], they own [area], you should know each other." That is not networking. That is the job.

One thing this week

Find one visibility task you have been carrying alone.

One meeting you always take solo. One update you always write. One narrative you always own. Pick one and find a way to either bring someone with you or hand it off with enough context that they could run it without you.

That is the practice. Do it once this week. Do it again next week. Over time, you will stop being the only one who knows how to make your team visible. And your team will stop depending on you to do it.

That is how a team stays visible when you move on.

Are there things you have been doing for your team that they would not know how to do without you?

You're great at the work. Let's make you impossible to ignore.

If you are looking for help developing a team that can advocate for itself and grow without depending on you to carry the visibility work, consider reaching out. jessestaffordcoaching.com

- **Related reading:**

- [Engineers Love Solving Problems. That's the Problem.](<https://medium.com/@stafford.jesse/engineers-love-solving-problems-thats-the-problem>)
- [Stop Managing Up and Start Showing Your Work](<https://medium.com/@stafford.jesse/stop-managing-up-and-start-showing-your-work>)

****Tags:**** Management, Leadership, Teamwork, Communication, Professional Development

[object Object] A leader at a whiteboard briefing a small team, pointing at a diagram showing work flowing outward to stakeholders. Brand blue #100299 tones, clean office setting, professional and collaborative. No text overlay. Realistic lighting. Sense of deliberate teaching, not presenting.